AI Prompt Engineering for Government Staff Work

Student Syllabus · One-day course · 8:00–4:00

Date: [DATE] · **Room:** [ROOM / BUILDING] · **Instructor:** [NAME], [EMAIL]

What this course is

A hands-on day on using your command's approved AI tool for everyday staff work. You'll learn to write prompts that work the first time, turn long, messy inputs into short products a senior leader can act on in under a minute, and build AI into the recurring tasks of your week, safely. You'll spend most of the day working in pairs, not listening. **There is no exam and no graded work.**

By 4:00 you'll be able to

1. **Explain how the AI produces its answers,** and follow the data rules for what may and may not go into it.
2. **Write a structured prompt** using the six slots (Task, Context, Audience, Format, Constraints, Example), and fix a weak one.
3. **Produce executive-ready products** with AI, such as a BLUF email, a one-page information paper, or a decision memo, and edit the draft until you'd sign it.
4. **Turn a recurring task into a reusable template** you can run every week.
5. **Check AI output against its source,** catch invented facts, and know when not to use AI.

The day

Time	Session	You'll practise
8:00	**Welcome**	The day's goals and the data rule
8:15	**How AI works, and the rules of the road**	Running one prompt twice; sorting what's OK to paste
9:15	*Break*	
9:30	**The six slots**	Rebuilding a vague prompt, one slot at a time
10:30	*Break*	
10:45	**Writing for executives**	Turning a wordy memo into a BLUF email
11:45	*Lunch (60 min)*	
12:45	**AI in your workflow**	Turning meeting notes into actions, an email, and a template
1:45	*Break*	
2:00	**Verify and judge**	Finding the errors in a confident AI summary
3:00	*Break*	
3:15	**Put it together**	Writing a decision memo from a raw email thread
3:45	**Close**	Your 30-day plan
4:00	*End*	

The one rule for today

> **Only the fabricated, unclassified course material goes into the AI.** Don't paste real work documents, names, or anything sensitive, even to "try it out." Every exercise text is invented for training.

At work afterwards, use only the AI tool your command has approved, and only for what it's authorized to hold. Your **data rules card** explains this.

What to bring

- `[Your government laptop and charger / CAC, as applicable]`
- A working login to `[APPROVED TOOL]`, tested before the day
- One recurring writing task from your job that takes too long. Describe it in general terms only

What you'll take home

Handout	What it's for
Data rules card	What may and may not go into the AI. Keep it on your desk
Six slots card	A checklist for any prompt. When the output disappoints, find the empty slot
Executive writing card	The four rules for busy readers, three prompt patterns, and a sign-off checklist
Prompt library	Eight starter templates for daily tasks: BLUF emails, action tables, status entries, decision memos, and more
Your own template	Built in the afternoon, for a task you do every week

Certificate of completion

Attend the full day to receive a certificate of completion. Sign in at 8:00 and again at 12:45. Certificates are sent within `[N]` business days.

How the day works

- **You'll work in pairs** on the approved tool. Talk through your prompts. Explaining why you wrote something is half the learning.
- **Start a new conversation for each test.** Earlier messages change later answers.
- **The AI drafts, and you sign.** Check every number, date, and name before anything goes up the chain.
- **Ask questions any time.** Policy questions the instructor can't answer go to `[AI / CYBERSECURITY OFFICE POC]`, and the answers come in the follow-up email.

After the course

You'll receive the handouts and the prompt library by email. At 30 days, we'll ask one question: which part of your 30-day plan actually happened?